



StayFocusd

This Chrome extension restricts the time you spend on time-wasting sites like Facebook to improve productivity!

tive (OSI) and the other is Stallman's Free Software Foundation (FSF). Both schools of thought have a few things in common and allow certain basic rights. These include the right to use, copy, modify to suit user need or create derivative works and redistribute software. Where the permissive and non-permissive licences differ is with respect to how each one is redistributed. The GNU GPL gives all rights but when it comes to redistribution, the provisions of the GNU GPL imply that the rights you got must be transferred to others. This means that GPLed code will forever remain GPLed.

The licence (in a viral manner) attaches itself to the entire code from then on. GPL is hence called a "copyleft" (as opposed to copyright) licence. Licences other than copyleft ones are permissive. Take the case of the BSD licence. It grants all the basic



rights; even when it comes to redistribution you're free to redistribute under a different licence. All that it asks is that you acknowledge the original

creators but not associate or use the original author's brand equity (so to speak) with your product. Therefore code under BSD can be used in proprietary software (and it often is). You can even choose a different licence for your product and charge fees. This is why characteristically on the spectrum it lies closer to public domain.

The licences themselves

What is a licence? Broken down, a licence is simply text that tells the user (and the world) how he or she may use the accompanying software and code. Back in the day when Open Source was gaining ground, many people came up with their own licences. On the OSI page that lists licences as per category, there are more than 50 licences (<http://www.opensource.org/licences/category>). Theoretically, if you understand legalese a bit and are smart enough to cover loopholes, you could come up with your own licence. Of course, it may not be approved by the OSI or FSF, but you could still use it.

Because projects (especially on the enterprise level) use code from a plethora of sources, it becomes difficult to keep track of the various samples and what licence governs them. Some developers (especially on the mobile side) and even large corporations don't really bother with any of the "licence stuff". But when working with parts of Open Source components, there should ideally be a concern for legalities. Should your application become widely used, and you've violated rights ascribed to a code package you've used, you're bound to face some action. Sometime back, Microsoft came under the radar for using GPLed code for one of its Windows 7 applications. When this news was publicised, not only was it embarrassing, but as per the licence norms Microsoft had to open source the code for that application. This disclosure spawned tracking software such as Developer Assistant from a IP company called Protecode. It ensures licence compliance by detecting violations in real time.

Which one is for you?

The answer to that question depends on a few factors. The first is: Did you write the code from scratch? If so, then the entire licence world is open for your picking. Heck, you can even keep it proprietary. The option to make money (and continue to be open source) is most easily available in this case. For example, Qt is available under both, GPL and Commercial licence as is the more famous MySQL.

But no one writes code from scratch these days. You take code from Open Source projects, mix and modify and build something of your own. In this case, what licence option is available to you depends entirely on what licence that code was governed

under. Copyleft licences like the GPL make the resultant software also GPL. Check up on the accompanying box for details on which one to use when. It's important to note that going in for custom or esoteric licences will deter contributors.

**We wish to evoke IANAL and TINLA clauses of the Internet Bylaws section C. We are not lawyers and this is not legal advice.*



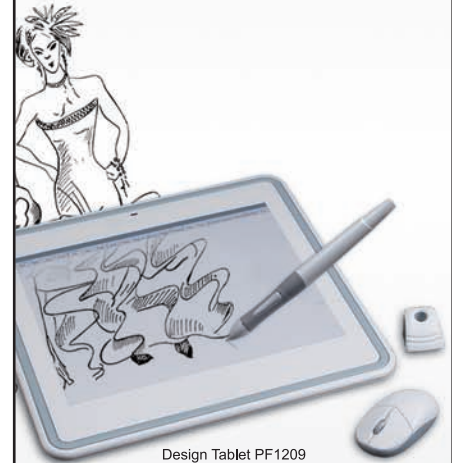
If you're still confused about which licence to use, you can take the help of this online tool to help you decide. All you have to do is tick the specific rights you wish to reserve, and the Licence Chooser will identify any licences that match your combination. Of course it's not exhaustive, but it does give a certain degree of information.

Link: http://three.org/openart/licence_chooser/



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